Laptop running slow: checks and fixes

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Summary

This article guides users and Desktop Support agents through diagnosing and resolving common performance issues on Acme Global laptops, such as sluggishness, freezing, high CPU usage, and long boot times. It outlines initial checks, a user-driven self-help cleanup procedure, the steps Desktop Support should take when the issue persists, and verification steps to confirm resolution.

Symptoms

- Laptop feels very slow during everyday tasks
- System hangs or freezes, especially during Teams calls
- High CPU usage shown in Task Manager (>80% sustained)
- Long boot times or delayed application launch
- Frequent spinning cursor or unresponsive UI

Common causes

- Too many startup programs consuming resources
- Accumulated temporary files and browser caches filling disk space
- Pending Windows/macOS updates pending reboot after extended uptime
- Insufficient RAM for current workload (often <8?GB)
- Disk fragmentation or near-capacity storage drive

Initial Checks

Before proceeding with any fixes, verify basic system health to avoid unnecessary work. Ensure the laptop is plugged into AC power (or has sufficient battery) and that you are logged in with your domain account. Open Task Manager (Ctrl+Shift+Esc) or Activity Monitor (macOS) and note the CPU, memory, and disk usage percentages. If any component is consistently above 80?%, record which processes are responsible. Also check for pending updates: Settings -> Windows Update -> View optional updates (or ? -> System Settings -> General -> Software Update). Finally, confirm that the laptop has been restarted within the last 48?hours; a long uptime can cause memory leaks and driver fatigue.

Self-Help Procedure (User)

Follow these steps to clean up common performance drains. Each step is safe to perform on Acme-managed devices and will not affect corporate data or settings. If you encounter a prompt for admin credentials, enter your domain password; if you do not have local admin rights, skip that step and inform the Service Desk.

1. 1. Close all non-essential applications and browser tabs.
2. Press Ctrl+Shift+Esc to open Task Manager.
3. Go to the Startup tab. Disable any items marked as "High" impact that you do not need at login (e.g., third-party chat utilities, game launchers, vendor tools). Keep corporate apps like Teams, Outlook, and OneDrive enabled.
4. Still in Task Manager, select the Performance tab -> Memory. Note the "In use" value. If it is near total capacity, proceed to step?5.
5. Open Settings -> System -> Storage. Under "Temporary files", select "Remove files" to delete temporary Windows files, recycle bin contents, and previous Windows installations.
6. Open your primary browser (Edge or Chrome). Clear browsing data: Settings -> Privacy, search, and services -> Clear browsing data -> choose "Cached images and files" and "Cookies and other site data" for the last 7 days, then click Clear now.
7. Run the built-in Disk Cleanup tool: search for "Disk Cleanup", select the C: drive, check "Temporary Internet Files", "Recycle Bin", and "Previous Windows installations", then click OK -> Delete Files.
8. Restart the laptop. After login, open Task Manager again and verify that CPU and memory usage have dropped below 50?% idle.

Service Desk Procedure (Desktop Support)

When a user reports persistent slowness after attempting the self-help steps, the Desktop Support agent should perform a deeper diagnostic and remediation. Begin by confirming the user's device details via Intune or the Asset Management console. Then execute the following checks in order, documenting findings in the ticket.

1. 1. Verify BIOS/UEFI version and ensure it is current (Dell/Lenovo/HP provide quarterly firmware updates via Intune).
2. Check disk health: run `wmic diskdrive get status` (Windows) or `diskutil info /` (macOS). Look for "OK" status; if any errors appear, escalate to the Hardware team for possible drive replacement.
3. Review installed software via Intune -> Devices -> {device name} -> Apps. Identify any non-standard or consumer-grade applications that may be consuming resources; advise the user to uninstall via Company Portal if not required.
4. Examine startup impact using Autoruns (Sysinternals) - disable any unnecessary third-party services that survived the user's cleanup.
5. Assess RAM utilization over a 15-minute period with Performance Monitor. If average memory usage exceeds 80?% and the device has less than 16?GB RAM, create a hardware upgrade request for RAM to 16?GB (standard for most Acme laptops).
6. Ensure all pending quality and feature updates are installed. If the device shows a pending restart, enforce a reboot and monitor for improvement.
7. If the drive is >85?% full, run a cleanup of user profiles (delete stale profiles, move large personal files to OneDrive, and advise the user to store data in the cloud).
8. After each remediation step, ask the user to test typical workload (e.g., join a Teams call, open Outlook, edit a document) and report any change in responsiveness.

Verification and Closure

Once the agreed-upon actions are complete, confirm that the laptop performs acceptably before closing the ticket. Ask the user to perform a brief usability test: open Outlook, join a short Teams meeting, and open a large Excel workbook. The system should respond within 2-3 seconds for each action, with CPU spikes staying under 70?% and memory usage stable. Document the final resource metrics (CPU, memory, disk usage) in the ticket resolution notes. If the user reports continued issues, escalate according to the escalation guidance below.

When to escalate

If after the Service Desk Procedure the laptop still exhibits high CPU (>80?% sustained), frequent freezes, or disk health errors, escalate to the Desktop Support senior team (or Hardware team for drive/RAM issues). Include in the escalation: device asset tag, current BIOS version, RAM size, storage type and usage percentage, list of startup items, and the exact symptoms observed during verification. For urgent P1 cases (e.g., user unable to work at all), contact the Desktop Support lead via phone extension 4357 and mark the ticket as P1.

Keywords: laptop slow, freezing, high CPU, performance, startup apps, temporary files, disk cleanup, RAM upgrade, Windows update, macOS update, Task Manager, Activity Monitor, BIOS, disk health, Intune, Company Portal